Cyber security

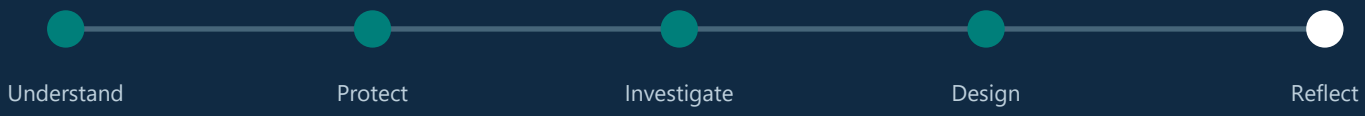
Your first 30 days.

A practical roadmap from first concepts to a small security project.

30
DAYS

60
MIN / DAY TOTAL

02
CONNECTED GUIDES



BUILT FOR YOUR SCHEDULE

Beginner level. One hour daily across both PDFs: 30 minutes of cybersecurity + 30 minutes of network security.

START HERE

Make the hour count

Read both guides at the same day number. The two tracks are one plan.

YOUR DAILY ROUTINE

00-30 MIN

Cybersecurity

5 read + 20 practice + 5 record

30-60 MIN

Network security

5 read + 20 practice + 5 record

Network-first is fine if it helps. Stop at 60 minutes; resource links are references for a short excerpt, not a requirement to complete entire courses.

A REALISTIC DAY-30 RESULT

- Explain basic risks, account controls and safe computing habits.
- Read a small log, separate evidence from assumptions, and outline a response.
- Create a short security plan for a fictional six-person office.

This is a foundation sprint: 30 hours combined, about 15 hours per subject. Professional competence and certification preparation require further practice.

HOW TO USE THE PAGES

PAGE	WHAT TO OPEN
03	Shared month map
04-06	Setup, core concepts and offline practice
07-16	Daily cards: days 1-30
17-19	Capstone, final check and answer guide
20 onward	Resource library, glossary and progress tracker

THE 30-DAY ROADMAP

One calendar. Two tracks.

One row = one hour. Use the detailed day cards for instructions.

DAY	CYBERSECURITY / 30 MIN	NETWORK SECURITY / 30 MIN
WEEK 1 / FOUNDATIONS		
01	Set up your learning notebook	Your first network map
02	Confidentiality, integrity, availability	Find your own IP settings
03	Make a tiny asset inventory	A gentle start to subnetting
04	Threat, vulnerability, control	TCP, UDP and ports
05	Spot and handle phishing	How names become addresses
06	Prioritize risks	Troubleshoot one layer at a time
07	Week 1 checkpoint	Week 1 checkpoint
WEEK 2 / PROTECTION		
08	Get comfortable with your operating system	Open a safe packet sample
09	Check updates and built-in protection	Read one packet carefully
10	Unique passwords and account inventory	Filter without losing evidence
11	MFA and recovery	Connect a request to its reply
12	Hashing versus encryption	Understand your host firewall
13	Rehearse a restore	Separate staff, guests and devices
14	Week 2 checkpoint	Week 2 checkpoint
WEEK 3 / OBSERVATION & RESPONSE		
15	Requests, sessions, and web trust	Describe normal traffic first
16	Authentication and authorization	Read a firewall log
17	Recognize two injection mistakes	What HTTPS protects
18	Read a few local events	A VPN is a tunnel
19	Build a small detection rule	Safer Wi-Fi and router administration
20	Respond without guessing	DNS privacy and trust
21	Week 3 checkpoint	A tiny incident walkthrough
WEEK 4 / BUILD YOUR PROJECT		
22	Capstone: know the office	Capstone: define the office
23	Give people the right access	Capstone: draw the boundaries
24	Pick the first three improvements	Capstone: write a small rule set
25	Plan a usable backup	Capstone: choose three priorities
26	Choose one useful alert	Capstone: attach a traffic note
27	Run a tabletop incident	Capstone: test the policy on paper
28	Finish your security brief	Capstone: make the handoff clear
FINISH / TEST & REFLECT		
29	Final knowledge check	Final knowledge check
30	Close the loop and plan the next month	Show the skills and plan month two

If you miss a day, resume in sequence. Use a review session to catch up; extend beyond the month when needed.

SETUP & STUDY HABITS

A small, workable lab

A laptop is helpful. The offline practice sheet keeps the plan usable without extra software.

ITEM	WHAT YOU NEED
Essentials	Browser, plain-text notes or a notebook, and a timer. No paid course or special computer is required.
Accounts	Use fictional examples by default. For personal account checks, never put passwords, codes or recovery secrets into your notes.
Optional tools	Built-in account/security settings and a local text editor. Web Academy labs are optional extensions, after the core month.
No-install route	Use the fictional messages, permissions and log on page 6. Observe settings without changing them if the device is shared or managed.

PRACTICE BOUNDARY

Use your own device, fictional data, or a training lab that explicitly permits the exercise. Keep capture analysis offline. Do not scan public targets, intercept other people's traffic, or test an employer or school network without permission.

YOUR EVIDENCE NOTE

For each day, record: date | day number | what I tried | one observation | why it matters | one question. A few lines or one annotated screenshot is enough. Redact personal identifiers before sharing.

WHEN SOMETHING BLOCKS YOU

- Spend at most five minutes troubleshooting setup, then use the offline alternative.
- On days 7, 14 and 21, repair one gap before starting any optional reading.
- If a concept is hard, draw it and explain it aloud in one sentence.

KEEP THIS PAGE HANDY

The ideas you will reuse

Cybersecurity protects systems, information and people. Network security focuses on the connections and traffic between systems.

IDEA	PLAIN-LANGUAGE MEANING	SMALL EXAMPLE
Confidentiality	Only the right people can read it.	An invoice is shared only with finance.
Integrity	Data stays correct and changes are controlled.	A payment amount cannot be silently edited.
Availability	The service is usable when needed.	A tested backup helps restore a lost file.
Threat / weakness / risk	A possible harm / an exploitable gap / the chance and impact of harm.	A stolen password is more damaging without MFA.
Authentication / authorization	Prove who you are / decide what you may do.	Sign in, then receive read-only access.
Least privilege	Give only the access needed for the job.	Use a normal account for everyday work.
Encryption / hashing	Protect readable data with a key / create a comparison digest.	Encrypt a device; hash a file to compare copies.

SIX WAYS TO ORGANIZE THE WORK

Govern: set responsibility. Identify: know assets and risks. Protect: put controls in place. Detect: notice unusual events. Respond: limit harm. Recover: restore and learn. These NIST CSF 2.0 functions overlap; they are not a one-time sequence.

Source: NIST CSF 2.0 small-business resources

DO NOT CONFUSE A SIGNAL WITH PROOF

A failed sign-in may be a typing error. An alert is a reason to investigate. Record the facts, consider a benign explanation, and choose the next check before declaring an incident.

FICTIONAL DATA / NO INSTALL

Your offline practice sheet

Use this page when a day card asks for a message, permission table, traffic sample or log.

A / MESSAGE TRIAGE

Message 1: "Your mailbox closes in 15 minutes. Open the attachment and enter your password and MFA code." Sender display name: IT Help. Address: help@support-example.invalid.

Message 2: "The monthly team guide is available in the usual company portal. Open it using your saved bookmark. No reply is needed." Sender: a familiar colleague.

Task: list two concerns in Message 1. Explain why Message 2 still needs context. Choose an independent way to verify each request. Do not open any attachment or submit any secrets.

B / WHO SHOULD HAVE ACCESS?

ROLE	STAFF GUIDE	CUSTOMER INVOICES
All staff	Read	No access
Finance	Read	Read and edit
Guest	No access	No access

Task: explain one allowed action and one denied action. Should being signed in automatically permit invoice editing?

C / A SMALL SIGN-IN LOG

TIME	ACCOUNT	EVENT
09:00	staff-01	Password accepted; MFA completed
09:03	staff-01	Password rejected
09:04	staff-01	Password rejected
09:05	staff-01	Password accepted; MFA rejected
09:10	staff-02	Password accepted; MFA completed

Task: make a five-event timeline. State what is observed, one possible benign explanation, and one follow-up question. This log does not establish an account compromise. Answers are on page 19.

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 01-03

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 01

Set up your learning notebook

Cybersecurity protects information, accounts, devices, and the services people depend on. Your first month builds a foundation, not expert status. You will learn by making small observations and recording evidence. A plain notebook and browser are enough to begin; special hacking software is not needed.

LEARN 5m Read the C1 guide's overview for five minutes.

PRACTICE 20m Create a folder called Security Learning with Notes and Evidence subfolders. Write your starting goal and the three devices or accounts you most want to understand.

SAVE + CHECK 5m One short starting page and an empty evidence folder. Can you name one thing you want to protect and explain why it matters?

REFERENCE: C1

DAY 02

Confidentiality, integrity, availability

Confidentiality means information is seen only by permitted people. Integrity means it stays accurate and is changed appropriately. Availability means it is usable when needed. These three ideas give you a simple way to explain the harm caused by a security failure before discussing tools or fixes.

LEARN 5m Read this explanation; scan the C1 guide's Identify section.

PRACTICE 20m Classify three fictional events: a leaked customer list, a changed invoice amount, and an unavailable booking system. For each, name the main security property affected and one possible control.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A three-row event / property / control table. Expected primary matches: confidentiality, integrity, availability. Some events affect more than one.

REFERENCE: C1

DAY 03

Make a tiny asset inventory

An asset is something valuable enough to protect: a laptop, a cloud account, a customer file, or a service. An inventory tells you what exists and who is responsible. You cannot make a useful security plan if you overlook where important information is stored or who can access it.

LEARN 5m Read only C1's Identify prompts.

PRACTICE 20m List five personal or fictional assets. Add owner, purpose, important data, and existing protection. Use labels such as Laptop A; leave serial numbers and account identifiers out of your notes.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Five asset rows with an owner and protection for each. Does your inventory include both a device and an account or service?

REFERENCE: C1

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 04-06

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 04 Threat, vulnerability, control

A threat is a possible cause of harm. A vulnerability is a weakness that could allow that harm. A control reduces the chance or impact of it. Keeping these ideas separate helps you describe a problem accurately: a stolen password, password reuse, and multifactor authentication play different roles.

LEARN 5m Review the glossary and C1's Protect section.

PRACTICE 20m Build three chains using your assets: threat / weakness / possible harm / control. Start with an account takeover made easier by a reused password; add two examples of your own.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Three simple risk chains. Can each proposed control address the weakness or reduce the harm you named?

REFERENCE: C1

DAY 05 Spot and handle phishing

Phishing tries to persuade a person to reveal information or perform an unsafe action, often by impersonating a trusted sender. Urgency and a familiar logo are not proof of legitimacy. A safer response is to verify a request through an independently known channel before taking the requested action.

LEARN 5m Read C2's recognition section and its example.

PRACTICE 20m Use Message 1 on page 6 or the example in C2. Mark three warning signs and one independent verification step. Draft a two-sentence practice report stating what arrived and what you did.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A marked-up example or five-line analysis; no message needs sending. Does your verification use a known website or contact, rather than the message's link?

REFERENCE: C2

DAY 06 Prioritize risks

Risk combines the possibility of an event with the harm it could cause. A simple low, medium, or high estimate is useful for learning, as long as you record your reasoning. The objective is to decide what deserves attention first, rather than assign impressive-looking but unsupported numbers.

LEARN 5m Review C1's risk discussion and your Day 4 chains.

PRACTICE 20m Choose three risks. Rate likelihood and impact as low, medium, or high with one reason each. Select a first action using both harm and the effort needed to reduce it.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Three ranked risks and one justified first action. Could another person understand your ranking from the reasons, even if they disagree?

REFERENCE: C1

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 07-09

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 07

Week 1 checkpoint

Review turns recently encountered words into knowledge you can use. Today is deliberately lighter: explain concepts without your notes, then correct the gaps. A short, clear explanation is better evidence of understanding than a page copied from a resource. Keep your corrections for the final review.

LEARN 5m Spend five minutes recalling the week's ideas without opening sources.

PRACTICE 20m Explain asset, threat, vulnerability, risk, and control in your own words. Apply all five to one lost laptop. Open your notes afterward and correct two weak explanations.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Five definitions, one example, and two corrections. Move on when you can distinguish the threat from the weakness and name a relevant control.

REFERENCE: C1

DAY 08

Get comfortable with your operating system

The operating system manages files, running programs, and access to the computer. Security work starts with finding these things confidently. A process is a running program; a permission determines an allowed action. Today you will observe your computer, rather than modify settings you do not yet understand.

LEARN 5m Read the opening of C3; optional Linux background is C12.

PRACTICE 20m On Windows, open Task Manager and identify your browser process. Create a harmless text file, then inspect Properties > Security if available. On another OS, use its process viewer and file-information panel.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Two notes: what a process is, and who can read your practice file. Can you distinguish a stored program from a running process? If permissions are unavailable, explain that limitation.

REFERENCE: C3 / C12

DAY 09

Check updates and built-in protection

Updates repair software defects, including some security weaknesses. Endpoint protection watches the computer for suspicious files or behavior. Neither gives a perfect guarantee, but both are useful layers. Before changing anything, learn where the status is shown and record what is current, missing, or unclear.

LEARN 5m Read C3's scan and protection overview.

PRACTICE 20m Inspect Windows Update status, your browser's About page, and Windows Security's protection status. Record three statuses. On a managed device or another OS, use its visible update/security pages and record inaccessible items.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A three-item protection baseline with one next action if needed. Can you identify a supported update path without downloading an unofficial updater?

REFERENCE: C3

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 10-12

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 10

Unique passwords and account inventory

If the same password protects several accounts, exposure at one service can endanger the others. Unique passwords limit that connection. A password manager can generate and store distinct credentials. Your learning record should describe the protection you use without containing actual passwords, recovery secrets, or complete account details.

LEARN 5m Review C2's account-protection advice.

PRACTICE 20m Privately review three of your own accounts. Record only whether each has a unique password and whether a password manager is used. Prioritize your main email account; draft one improvement without recording a secret.

SAVE + CHECK 5m An anonymized three-row account checklist. Why can a unique password help even when another service has a breach?

REFERENCE: C2 / C4

DAY 11

MFA and recovery

Multifactor authentication adds evidence beyond a password, such as possession of an authenticator or security key. Recovery is part of the design: you need a safe way back in if a device is lost. Two passwords are still one factor type. The exact setup depends on the account provider.

LEARN 5m Read C4's setup and recovery notes, or your provider's equivalent.

PRACTICE 20m Inspect one personal account's MFA and recovery settings. Record status and a recovery plan using no secrets. If already ready, enable the provider-supported method; otherwise keep the written setup plan as today's completed task.

SAVE + CHECK 5m MFA status, chosen method, and recovery location described without revealing codes. Can you explain what you would do if your phone were lost?

REFERENCE: C4

DAY 12

Hashing versus encryption

Encryption protects readability using a key. A cryptographic hash produces a fixed-length fingerprint used to check data integrity; it does not conceal the original file. A matching hash is meaningful only when the expected value comes from a trusted source. A hash by itself does not prove a file is harmless.

LEARN 5m Read C5's Description and Example 1.

PRACTICE 20m Save practice.txt inside your learning folder. In PowerShell run Get-FileHash -LiteralPath 'FULL_PATH_TO_PRACTICE_FILE' -Algorithm SHA256, replacing the placeholder. Change one letter in the file, save it, and run the command again.

SAVE + CHECK 5m The two hashes and one sentence explaining why they changed. If PowerShell is unavailable, use the documented example to explain the expected result; why is hashing not encryption?

REFERENCE: C5

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 13-15

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 13

Rehearse a restore

A backup is useful only if you can restore the information you need. Synchronization alone can propagate deletions or unwanted changes. Today's tiny rehearsal teaches the restore workflow with invented data. Two folders on one computer demonstrate copying, but do not protect you if that computer or its drive fails.

LEARN 5m Read C1's Recover prompts and today's explanation.

PRACTICE 20m Create a dummy note, copy it into a folder named Restore Practice Copy, then change the original. Copy the earlier version back under a new filename and open it to confirm the contents.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A verified restored dummy file and a note about where an independent backup could live. Would both local folders survive a failed drive? Explain why a separate, recoverable copy matters.

REFERENCE: C1

DAY 14

Week 2 checkpoint

Hardening means reducing unnecessary exposure and improving protective settings. A useful baseline is a short record of what was actually observed, not an assumption that everything is secure. Today you will collect your week's observations and distinguish completed checks from improvements that still require follow-up.

LEARN 5m Review your Days 8-13 evidence for five minutes.

PRACTICE 20m Make a six-row baseline: update status, protection status, account privilege, password uniqueness, MFA/recovery, and backup/restore. Mark each observed, planned, or unknown and choose the most useful next improvement.

SAVE + CHECK 5m One compact baseline with evidence references. Can you explain hash versus encryption, MFA versus two passwords, and a local copy versus a resilient backup?

REFERENCE: C3 / C4 / C5

DAY 15

Requests, sessions, and web trust

A browser sends requests and receives responses. A website often uses a session identifier to recognize a signed-in user across requests. Treat that identifier like a secret. HTTPS protects transport between endpoints; a site still needs sound authentication, permission checks, and safe handling of the data people submit.

LEARN 5m Read C7's request/response overview.

PRACTICE 20m Open a public documentation page. Press F12 or open Developer Tools > Network, reload, and select the main document request. Record its method and status code only; identify where response headers appear.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A method/status pair and a three-box browser > request > server sketch. Does HTTPS alone decide whether one user may view another user's private file?

REFERENCE: C7 / C8

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 16-18

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 16

Authentication and authorization

Authentication checks who a user is; authorization checks what that user may do. Hiding a button or using an unusual page address does not enforce permission. The server must check access to the requested resource. Understanding this distinction prepares you to reason about both web applications and shared cloud files.

LEARN 5m Read C8's opening sections.

PRACTICE 20m Draw a customer/admin permission table for viewing and deleting records. Use page 6 as a model. Explain why each action is allowed or denied and where a server must enforce that decision.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A two-role permission table and one needed server-side check. Why is a hidden administrative link insufficient protection?

REFERENCE: C8

DAY 17

Recognize two injection mistakes

SQL injection occurs when untrusted input changes a database command's meaning. Cross-site scripting can make a browser interpret unsafe content as code. Both involve mixing data and instructions, but the defenses differ. You only need to recognize the distinction today; writing or exploiting an application is outside this short exercise.

LEARN 5m Read C13's definition and C14's introductory output-encoding explanation.

PRACTICE 20m Write two fictional bug cards: user input joined into a database query; a comment rendered as active page content. Match the first to parameterized queries and the second to context-appropriate output encoding or safe rendering.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Two bug / possible impact / defense cards. Which problem affects database commands, and which affects how a browser interprets content?

REFERENCE: C13 / C14

DAY 18

Read a few local events

A log records events that software chooses to capture. Useful fields include time, source, action, and outcome. A warning is a clue to investigate, not automatic proof of an attack. Logs may be incomplete, and personal details can appear in them, so your learning notes should keep only the fields needed.

LEARN 5m Read C10's Event attributes section; use C6 as a command reference.

PRACTICE 20m Open Event Viewer > Windows Logs > Application and inspect three events. Note time, source, ID and a short summary. If unavailable, use three sign-in rows on page 6 and mark fields not supplied as unknown.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Three sanitized event summaries, with one uncertainty clearly labeled. Why does a warning-level event alone fail to prove compromise?

REFERENCE: C6 / C10

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 19-21

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 19 Build a small detection rule

Detection looks for patterns worth checking. A simple rule can flag repeated failed sign-ins, but ordinary mistakes can trigger it too. Such a false positive is not a reason to ignore every alert. Good investigation combines the pattern with context, such as a user's explanation and other account activity.

LEARN 5m Read C10's authentication-event guidance.

PRACTICE 20m Use this fictional sequence for account A: 09:00 fail; 09:01 fail; 09:02 fail; 09:03 success. Apply the teaching rule 'three failures within five minutes'. Write two possible explanations and one question to investigate next.

SAVE + CHECK 5m One alert, two hypotheses, and one evidence request. The rule fires; the sequence does not establish whether the successful sign-in was legitimate. Explain what is missing.

REFERENCE: C10

DAY 20 Respond without guessing

Incident response coordinates how people assess a suspected security problem, limit harm, restore trusted operation, and learn from it. Preparation includes knowing who to contact and what evidence matters. A beginner's job is to report observations accurately and follow an agreed process, not improvise destructive repairs from an uncertain alert.

LEARN 5m Read C11's abstract and C1's Respond and Recover prompts.

PRACTICE 20m For a fictional employee who entered a password on a suspicious page, draft five steps: record facts, notify the responsible person, secure the account from a trusted device, review access/session activity, and verify recovery. State what is still unknown.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A five-step response draft with an owner and evidence to preserve. Does your plan distinguish confirmed facts from suspicion and include a recovery check?

REFERENCE: C11 / C1

DAY 21 Week 3 checkpoint

A security finding should connect evidence to a plausible risk and a useful next action. Technical terms alone do not make the conclusion stronger. Today you will combine the web and investigation ideas in a short explanation that a nontechnical colleague could understand, including what the evidence does not prove.

LEARN 5m Review your Day 16 permission table and Day 19 alert.

PRACTICE 20m Write a 100-word note covering one missing permission check or suspicious sign-in pattern. Include observation, potential impact, uncertainty, and recommended action. Then explain authentication, authorization, and a false positive aloud.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A clear finding and three spoken definitions. Can a reader identify both the evidence and the limit of your conclusion?

REFERENCE: C8 / C10 / C11

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 22-24

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 22 Capstone: know the office

Your fictional office has six staff laptops, one shared printer, three Internet of Things devices, guest Wi-Fi, and cloud files. The network track will design the segments and connections. In this track you will decide who owns the information, which risks matter most, and how people should protect and recover it.

LEARN 5m Review C1's Identify section and the capstone scenario.

PRACTICE 20m Create five asset groups: staff laptops, printer, IoT devices, cloud accounts/files, and guest access. Give each a fictional owner and identify the two most important kinds of business data.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A five-row office inventory with two data priorities. Are responsibility and information value visible, rather than only device counts?

REFERENCE: C1

DAY 23 Give people the right access

Least privilege means giving a person only the access needed for a task. It reduces the harm of mistakes and compromised accounts. A small office still benefits from named accounts, a defined administrator, and clear steps when someone joins or leaves. Network location alone should not grant permission to cloud files.

LEARN 5m Review C8's access-control definition and your Day 11 notes.

PRACTICE 20m Make an access table for owner, staff, and guest against customer files and settings administration. Add MFA for cloud accounts and a one-line rule to remove access when a staff member leaves.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A three-role access matrix plus an offboarding rule. Can guests access private files? Does routine staff work require administrator privileges? Explain your choices.

REFERENCE: C8 / C4

DAY 24 Pick the first three improvements

A small team cannot do every security task at once. Choose a few controls that address the most important weaknesses and assign responsibility. Your recommendation becomes more useful when it includes how someone will confirm it is working. Label invented details as assumptions instead of pretending an inspection took place.

LEARN 5m Review your Day 6 risk ranking and Day 14 baseline.

PRACTICE 20m Choose three office risks, such as account takeover, outdated laptops, and accidental file loss. For each write one control, a fictional owner, and an observable verification step. Mark the whole exercise as a proposed design.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Three prioritized risk / control / owner / verification rows. Does every proposed improvement reduce a named risk and have a way to check it?

REFERENCE: C1 / C3 / C4

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 25-27

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 25 Plan a usable backup

Recovery needs a clear answer to what data is protected, how much recent work could be lost, and how long the office can tolerate disruption. These are business choices, not magic technical settings. A small backup plan should also say who restores files and how that person proves the restored copy works.

LEARN 5m Review your Day 13 restore notes and C1's Recover section.

PRACTICE 20m For fictional cloud customer files, propose daily backup, a protected copy independent of ordinary synchronization, and a monthly sample restore. Set teaching targets: no more than one working day of lost changes and restoration within one working day.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Four lines covering data, independent copy, owner, and restore test; label targets as assumptions. Could an ordinary account deleting a file also destroy every recovery copy? Revise the design if yes.

REFERENCE: C1

DAY 26 Choose one useful alert

A detection plan must connect an event to a person who can act. Collecting every possible log creates work without guaranteeing useful answers. Start with one high-value question, the minimum records needed to investigate it, and a clear route for reviewing the result. Protect the logs because they can contain sensitive information.

LEARN 5m Review C10's Event attributes and Data to exclude.

PRACTICE 20m Reuse your Day 19 teaching rule for the office's cloud accounts. Specify the needed fields, who reviews an alert, and two checks before calling it an incident. Add a note to avoid storing passwords or session tokens.

SAVE + CHECK 5m One five-line detection-and-review rule. Can the named reviewer determine who, when, and what happened without capturing secrets?

REFERENCE: C10

DAY 27 Run a tabletop incident

A tabletop is a discussion or written rehearsal using invented events. It tests whether a plan is understandable before a real problem occurs. Use yesterday's alert and add an employee report of a suspicious sign-in prompt. You must decide what to check and who acts without assuming that every possible harm already occurred.

LEARN 5m Review your Day 20 response draft.

PRACTICE 20m Write a four-entry timeline: employee reports; owner assesses; owner secures account and reviews sessions/sharing; owner verifies safe access and records a lesson. State one evidence item and one unresolved question at each stage.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A short fictional incident timeline with responsibilities. Did you include both protecting the account and checking whether files or sharing settings changed?

REFERENCE: C11 / C4

DAILY FIELDWORK

Days 28-30

Each card: 5 min learn + 20 min practice + 5 min save and check.

DAY 28 Finish your security brief

Your capstone is a small portfolio artifact showing how your reasoning connects. A reader should see the assets, the priorities, the proposed protections, and the plan for a suspected incident. Keep it compact and honest: it is a fictional design and rehearsal, not proof that a real office was tested or secured.

LEARN 5m Review the capstone rubric for five minutes.

PRACTICE 20m Combine Days 22-27 into one or two pages: assets, three risks, access rules, backup plan, alert and response timeline. Reference the network diagram. Remove duplicated text and explain unusual terms.

SAVE + CHECK 5m A one- or two-page cybersecurity brief joined to the network design. Can each important risk be traced to a control, an owner, and a verification step?

REFERENCE: C1 / C10 / C11

DAY 29 Final knowledge check

Assessment should test what you can explain and demonstrate, rather than how many pages you read. Work without notes first, then check your answers. Mistakes are a map of what to practice next. A month of short sessions can establish habits and basic reasoning, but it does not establish professional readiness.

LEARN 5m Prepare a blank page. Open the ten prompts on page 18 and keep page 19 closed.

PRACTICE 20m Answer the ten questions on page 18 in your own words, using about two minutes per question. Short examples are enough.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Ten answers, a score out of ten, and your two least-confident topics. Use page 19 for scoring. Aim for 8/10; repair the weakest answers on day 30.

REFERENCE: C1 / C8 / C10

DAY 30 Close the loop and plan the next month

Useful progress is visible in your explanations and evidence: you now have a risk table, a protection baseline, a restore rehearsal, a log interpretation, and a small office design. The next step is deeper repetition in a chosen direction. Keep a steady schedule rather than collecting a long list of unfinished courses.

LEARN 5m Review your Day 29 gaps and the capstone rubric.

PRACTICE 20m Correct the two weakest answers, score your capstone, and choose one next-month direction: defensive investigation, web security, or Linux fundamentals. Plan two weekly practice sessions and one weekly review using a listed official resource.

SAVE + CHECK 5m Corrected answers, a capstone score, and a four-week continuation note. Is the next plan specific about one resource, a repeatable task, and evidence of progress?

REFERENCE: C6 / C8 / C9 / C10 / C12

DAYS 22-28 / SHARED CAPSTONE

A small office, made safer

Build this in pieces during the daily sessions. A paper design is enough.

THE SCENARIO

A six-person office has six laptops, one shared printer, three IoT devices, guest Wi-Fi and cloud files. The owner wants fewer account risks and clear boundaries between staff, guests and devices. All details are fictional.

YOUR PART OF THE FINAL PROJECT

- A five-item asset list and three prioritized risks, each with an owner and a practical control.
- An access plan for owner, staff and guests; an MFA and account recovery checklist.
- A backup/restore plan, one alert rule and a short response note: evidence, first action, contact and recovery check.

Combine both tracks into one 2-4 page portfolio note. Use a short table and diagram; mark controls as proposed or observed. Do not claim deployment or successful testing of a paper design.

PROJECT SCORE / 10 POINTS PER TRACK

CRITERION	PTS	FULL CREDIT
Assets and scope	2	Five assets and clear boundaries.
Risk reasoning	2	Three risks with plausible impact and priority.
Controls and ownership	2	A useful control and owner for each risk.
Response and recovery	2	Evidence, containment choice, contact and restore check.
Clarity and honesty	2	Readable, no secrets, proposals distinguished from tests.

Use 0 = missing, 1 = partly clear, 2 = clear and correct. Aim for 8/10 on each track; repair the weakest item on day 30. This is a self-assessment, not an accredited qualification.

DAY 29 / CLOSED-NOTES CHECK

Can you explain it simply?

5 min prepare + 20 min answer + 5 min score. Repair weak areas on day 30.

01 Give one example each of confidentiality, integrity and availability.

02 A scammer tries a reused password on an account without MFA. Identify the threat, weakness and possible impact.

03 How is authentication different from authorization?

04 Why is a unique password plus MFA safer than a reused password? Name one recovery precaution.

05 Name two warning signs in a message and one independent verification method.

06 How do encryption and hashing serve different purposes?

07 What does least privilege mean for an everyday computer account?

08 Does a burst of failed sign-ins prove an intrusion? Name one next check.

09 What evidence would you record before responding to a suspicious sign-in?

10 How would you verify that a file backup is usable?

SCORE / 10

Give yourself one point for each complete answer. Use page 19. 8-10: continue practicing; 5-7: revisit the weakest topics; 0-4: repeat the foundations before adding new tools.

ANSWER GUIDE

Check your reasoning

Use after attempting the exercises. Equivalent correct explanations earn credit.

OFFLINE PRACTICE / PAGE 6

A: urgency, an unexpected attachment and demands for passwords or MFA codes are warning signs. Verify using a known contact route or saved portal address. Familiar names and calm wording do not prove authenticity. B: staff can read the guide; only finance may edit invoices. Signing in does not grant every permission. C: three unsuccessful attempts appear at 09:03-09:05; a different user succeeds at 09:10. Typos or an unsolicited attempt are both possible. Verify with the account owner and review source/device details before concluding compromise.

DAY-29 ANSWERS / ONE POINT EACH

01. C: limit invoice access. I: prevent unauthorized amount changes. A: restore needed files after failure.

02. Threat: attempted account access. Weakness: reused password/no MFA. Impact: data loss or unauthorized changes.

03. Authentication verifies identity; authorization decides allowed actions.

04. Unique secrets limit password reuse attacks; MFA adds a factor. Keep recovery methods secure and accessible.

05. Examples: urgency and requests for secrets. Verify through a known phone number or independently opened portal.

06. Encryption is reversible with the right key; hashing creates a digest for comparison. A hash alone does not prove trust.

07. Use only required permissions; use elevated access only when necessary.

08. No. Check source/device, surrounding events and the account owner's explanation.

09. Record timestamps with timezone, account, device/source, event result and where the evidence came from.

10. Restore a harmless file to a different location and open/compare it with the original.

These are model answers for this study plan. Real investigations require more context and verification.

ONE WORKED RISK RECORD

ASSET / RISK	CONTROL / OWNER	HOW TO CHECK
Cloud files: account takeover could expose customer data.	Unique credentials and MFA; office owner coordinates setup.	Review MFA status and recovery route without copying secrets.
Priority assumption: high impact because files contain customer details.	Add least-privilege sharing and a recoverable independent copy.	Inspect sharing permissions and restore one harmless test file.

RESOURCES / START WITH THESE

A focused resource shelf

Open only the topic linked by today's card. Longer courses are optional after day 30.

C1

NIST CSF 2.0: Small Business Quick Start Guide

Free public guidance; checked 8 September 2026.

Use the linked Small Business Quick Start Guide. Read only the section named for the day, not the entire framework.

https://www.nist.gov/itl/smallbusinesscyber/nist-cybersecurity-framework-0

C2

FTC: How to recognize and avoid phishing scams

Free public article; checked 8 September 2026.

Use its example and recognition advice. Reporting destinations in this US resource may differ from your country or employer.

https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-recognize-avoid-phishing-scams

C3

Microsoft: Virus and threat protection in Windows Security

Free public documentation; Windows features vary by device.

A reference for inspecting the protection already on your computer; no extra antivirus purchase is needed for this plan.

https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/security/threat-malware-protection/virus-and-threat-protection-in-the-windows-security-app

C4

Microsoft: Two-step verification for your account

Free instructions; a Microsoft account is needed to change its settings.

Use your own account provider's equivalent if different. Understand recovery before changing sign-in settings.

https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/accounts-billing/security/how-to-use-two-step-verification-with-your-microsoft-account

C5

Microsoft Learn: Get-FileHash

Free documentation; PowerShell command available on Windows.

Read Description and Example 1. SHA-256 is used in the small local integrity exercise.

https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/powershell/module/microsoft.powershell.utility/get-filehash

Resource links researched on 8 September 2026. Access conditions can change; the offline sheets remain available. No purchase is needed for the core plan.

RESOURCES / CONTINUED

A focused resource shelf

Open only the topic linked by today's card. Longer courses are optional after day 30.

C6

Microsoft Learn: Get-WinEvent

Free documentation; the command reads Windows event logs.

The plan reads a few Application events only. Some logs require additional permissions; use the supplied sample when access is unavailable.

https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/powershell/module/microsoft.powershell.diagnostics/get-winevent

C7

MDN: Overview of HTTP

Free public article.

Read only the request/response overview. The network companion covers the connection underneath it.

https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/HTTP/Guides/Overview

C8

PortSwigger: Access control vulnerabilities

Free reading.

Read What is access control? and Unprotected functionality. The goal is explaining the missing permission check.

https://portswigger.net/web-security/access-control

C9

PortSwigger: Unprotected admin functionality lab

Free Academy lab; account/sign-in may be required to launch and track it.

Optional guided browser-only practice. Use the lab's own solution, stay in its assigned instance, and stop after 15 minutes. No Burp installation is required for this exercise.

https://portswigger.net/web-security/access-control/lab-unprotected-admin-functionality

C10

OWASP: Logging Cheat Sheet

Free public technical guidance.

Read only Event attributes and Data to exclude. Passwords, session tokens, and private data do not belong in your learning notes.

https://cheatsheetseries.owasp.org/cheatsheets/Logging_Cheat_Sheet.html

Resource links researched on 8 September 2026. Access conditions can change; the offline sheets remain available. No purchase is needed for the core plan.

RESOURCES / CONTINUED

A focused resource shelf

Open only the topic linked by today's card. Longer courses are optional after day 30.

C11

NIST SP 800-61 Rev. 3: Incident response

Free public guidance; published April 2025.

Read the abstract first. This is a reference for the tabletop response exercise, not a required cover-to-cover assignment.

https://www.nist.gov/publications/incident-response-recommendations-and-considerations-cybersecurity-risk-management-csf

C12

Ubuntu: The Linux command line for beginners

Free public tutorial.

Optional next-month resource. Read the terminal and file-navigation sections; do not install Linux for this month's core plan.

https://ubuntu.com/tutorials/command-line-for-beginners

C13

OWASP: SQL Injection Prevention Cheat Sheet

Free public technical guidance.

Read What is a SQL Injection Attack? and the introduction to parameterized queries. Coding is not required.

https://cheatsheetseries.owasp.org/cheatsheets/SQL_Injection_Prevention_Cheat_Sheet.html

C14

OWASP: Cross Site Scripting Prevention Cheat Sheet

Free public technical guidance.

Read Introduction and the output-encoding overview. Use it to contrast browser-side and database-side mistakes.

https://cheatsheetseries.owasp.org/cheatsheets/Cross_Site_Scripting_Prevention_Cheat_Sheet.html

Resource links researched on 8 September 2026. Access conditions can change; the offline sheets remain available. No purchase is needed for the core plan.

QUICK GLOSSARY

Speak the language

Use these short definitions when a new term interrupts your practice.

Asset

Something valuable to protect, including data, accounts, devices, and services.

Confidentiality

Keeping information accessible only to permitted people or systems.

Integrity

Preserving the correctness of information and appropriate control over changes.

Availability

Keeping information and services usable when they are needed.

Threat

A possible cause of harm to an asset.

Vulnerability

A weakness that can enable or increase harm.

Risk

The possibility and consequences of a harmful event.

Control

A measure that reduces the likelihood or impact of a security problem.

Authentication

Checking the identity a person or system claims.

Authorization

Deciding which actions an identified or anonymous user may perform.

Least privilege

Giving only the access needed for a task, for only as long as needed.

MFA

Authentication using more than one factor type, such as a password plus a security key.

Hash

A fixed-length value derived from data, often used to check integrity.

Encryption

A reversible transformation using keys that protects the readability of information.

Malware

Software designed to perform harmful or unwanted actions.

Phishing

Deceptive communication intended to induce unsafe action or disclosure.

Session

A way an application associates multiple requests with a continuing interaction, often after sign-in.

Log

A recorded event or collection of events produced by a system or application.

False positive

An alert that suggests a problem when the investigated activity is actually benign.

Incident response

Coordinated work to assess a security problem, limit harm, recover, and improve.

EXPLAIN IT WITHOUT THE ACRONYM

Choose three terms and explain each using an everyday example. If you need to reread the definition, add the term to your next review session.

PRINTABLE TRACKER

Turn practice into progress

Check a day only when you have saved an observation and answered its check.

START DATE _____

01 ☐	02 ☐	03 ☐	04 ☐	05 ☐	06 ☐
07 ☐	08 ☐	09 ☐	10 ☐	11 ☐	12 ☐
13 ☐	14 ☐	15 ☐	16 ☐	17 ☐	18 ☐
19 ☐	20 ☐	21 ☐	22 ☐	23 ☐	24 ☐
25 ☐	26 ☐	27 ☐	28 ☐	29 ☐	30 ☐

AFTER EACH WEEK

The concept I can now explain: _____

The task I want to repeat: _____

My next small improvement: _____

AFTER DAY 30 / KEEP THE SAME ONE-HOUR HABIT

Next month: choose one direction. For defensive work, repeat log triage and response notes; for web security, follow guided Web Security Academy fundamentals. Add basic Linux and scripting gradually.